relations. His visit to China in December 1989 was symbolic in the sense that India accepted the Chinese viewpoint of broadening exchange in other areas without making these developments contingent on the resolution of the border issue. A much more relaxed relationship evolved after Rajiv Gandhi's visit to China, which was briefly disturbed due to the Pokhran explosion of May 1998. Nevertheless, after a short interregnum of strained relations between the two, normalcy returned and relations continued on the course set by Rajiv Gandhi.

Rajiv Gandhi tried to mend fences and took several confidence-building measures to boost India's relations with Pakistan. After the death of General Zia-ul-Haq (17 August 1988) in a plane crash, democracy was restored in Pakistan for a very brief period under Benazir Bhutto, which was welcomed by India. Rajiv Gandhi even went to Islamabad to attend the SAARC Summit (1988) and held "constructive and cordial talks" with his Pakistani counterpart. But his hopes were soon belied and he became apprehensive of Pakistan's endeavour to develop its nuclear capacity, particularly Benazir Bhutto's visit to Pyongyang to negotiate a deal for the exchange of missiles and missile technology from North Korea. Thus, Rajiv Gandhi made efforts to secure India's security by advocating nuclear and general disarmament.

The tensions emanating in Sri Lanka due to ethnic conflict also affected India's domestic politics and also her security when a large number of Tamilians fled from Sri Lanka and crossed over to India. This created a serious refugee problem for India. Tensions cropped up between India and Sri Lanka, especially due to air-dropping of supplies for the suffering Tamilians. Improvement of bilateral relationship began with the signing of the accord between Rajiv Gandhi and President Jayewardane on 29 July 1987. The Indian Peacekeeping Force's (IPKF) action thereafter, drew criticisms from different quarters and is seen as India's greatest foreign policy blunder, yet it had helped in restoring peace in Sri Lanka.

Alongside the traditional concerns of Indian Foreign Policy, Rajiv Gandhi realized the changed global economic scenario. Therefore, on the economic front due to the globalization and liberalization spree, Rajiv Gandhi wanted to introduce changes to the old